

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 27, 2025

Measles death puts focus on RFK Jr.

Next in line

As it continues making cuts, the administration is now turning its attention to career officials with civil service protection. **A6.**

Mineral deal

Trump says Zelensky will visit the White House on Friday to sign the pact. **A4.**

Staff is back

Five recently laid off employees at the JFK Library have been rehired. **B2.**

Says outbreak ‘not unusual’; Texas child wasn’t vaccinated

By Michael Levenson,
Teddy Rosenbluth,
and Apoorva Mandavilli
NEW YORK TIMES

A child has died of measles in West Texas, the first known death in an outbreak that is spreading in the region and in neighboring New Mexico, state health officials said Wednesday.

The patient was an unvaccinated school-age child, according to officials in Lubbock, Texas, and the Department of State Health Services.

The outbreak comes amid growing concerns among public health experts about declining

vaccination rates and the confirmation of Robert F. Kennedy Jr., a prominent vaccine skeptic, as the nation’s health secretary.

At a meeting of Cabinet officials at the White House on Wednesday, Kennedy downplayed the news, saying that federal health officials are “watching” the outbreak and noting that there have been others this year.

“So it’s not unusual,” he said. He did not mention vaccination or describe steps the federal government might be taking to help stop the outbreak.

In “The Measles Book,” published by Children’s Health De-

fense, the antivaccine nonprofit he founded, Kennedy wrote that “measles outbreaks have been fabricated to create fear,” leading government officials to “inflict unnecessary and risky vaccines on millions of children for the sole purpose of fattening industry profits.”

As of Feb. 20, there had been three measles outbreaks in the United States this year and 16 last year, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The outbreaks last year totaled 285 cases; this year’s tally so far is nearly half that.

MEASLES, Page A5

‘It’s one of those things you either pay now or pay later.’

PATRICK M. KEEFE JR., *mayor of Revere*

New school costs soared in Mass. over last 5 years

High interest rates, inflation among factors

By James Vaznis
GLOBE STAFF

The price tag for new public schools in Massachusetts has risen sharply over the last five years, with high schools increasingly exceeding \$300 million and at least two projects each likely to cost more than \$700 million.

Waltham High School kicked off classes this year in a new state-of-the-art facility that cost \$374 million. Lowell is in the midst of a \$381 million renovation of its 3,000-student high school campus, which straddles a downtown canal, and Revere is preparing to erect a \$493 million high school on the former Wonderland greyhound racing track.

The cost of those projects, however, could soon be eclipsed by others that are under development: Lexington is planning a \$662 million project for its high school, and Brockton and Boston are preparing for massive high school renovation projects with early rough estimates exceeding \$700 million for each.

Brockton is home to the state’s largest high school, with 3,600 students, which is contributing to its huge price tag, while Boston is planning to overhaul its only vocational high school, Madison Park, which might accommodate up to 2,000 students.

SCHOOLS, Page A10

CENTER OF ATTENTION



MARK SCHIEFELBEIN/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Surrounded Wednesday by Capitol Police, protesters at the Cannon House Office Building decried cuts to US foreign aid.

Border czar revels in taking hardest line

Homan vows to bring ‘hell’ to Boston because of its sanctuary city policies

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Tom Homan spent the past four years angry about illegal immigration. Now he’s back in a position to do something about it, and he’s not pulling any punches.

“I [woke] up every day for the last four years pissed off because the Biden administration took the most secure border in my lifetime and unsecured it on purpose,” Homan, 63, a tough-talking former Border Patrol agent, told the Conservative Political Action Conference in Maryland



ALEX WROBLEWSKI/AFP VIA GETTY

Tom Homan was again lured out of retirement by Donald Trump.

on Saturday. When President Trump asked him to be “border czar,” Homan said he responded, “I’ll come back and I’ll do it for free, I’m so pissed off.”

After taking shots at Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez of New York and Illinois Governor JB Pritzker — both Democrats who have criticized him — he turned his attention to Boston Police Commissioner Michael Cox.

“You’re not a police commissioner,” Homan said of Cox to the conference crowd after vowing he’d be “bringing hell with me” to Boston because of its so-called sanctuary city policies. “Take that badge off your chest, put it in the desk drawer because you

became a politician.”

In a way, the same could be said of Homan, who has transformed from dutiful civil servant — in 2015, he earned the nation’s highest civil service award during the Obama administration — to full-throated Trump supporter and conservative darling. Lured out of retirement this year for the second time by Trump, Homan has become the face of the administration’s mass deportation efforts in his role as border czar.

And some former colleagues said his ramped-up rhetoric is surprising even for someone known for being blunt.

“I never heard the kind of

BORDER, Page A7

Putting their water meters on notice

Some vigilant residents claim they’re paying for phantom leaks, but Somerville isn’t sold

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — Walter Sass had a leak. Or so said the readings from his water meter.

In February of last year, he said, the meter showed the pipes in his Somerville home were steadily losing large amounts of water, at a rate of about 36 gallons a day.

He looked everywhere, even turning off the flow of water to sections of his house one by one. But try as he might, he couldn’t seem to find its source.

That’s when a new hypothesis occurred to him: It was the meter.

Sass built his “rig,” as he calls it, a device he said offers proof that something is amiss.

Now he and other basement tinkerers are using their science backgrounds to plead their case to the city — and getting the attention of city councilors in the process — that water meters are vastly overcharging them. If they’re right, it could mean that at a time of sky-high utility bills, hundreds of Somerville residents are paying way

WATER, Page A10



And snow it goes

Thursday: Showers, mild. High 49-54. Low 36-41.

Friday: Sunny, windy. High 41-46. Low 27-32.

Sunrise: 6:23 Sunset: 5:32

Weather and Comics, D5-6. Obituaries, C9.

VOL. 307, NO. 58

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



State Representative Jeffrey Roy, who is dating a lobbyist, was promoted by House Speaker Ron Mariano into his leadership team, but lost a chairman post. **B1.**

Businesses in downtown Boston say safety issues are a major concern, with public drug use keeping customers away. **D1.**

Governor Maura Healey pledged to file legislation that would address energy affordability. **D1.**

After years of decline, the Christian population in the United States has stabilized, a shift fueled in part by young adults. **A2.**

The Green Line will get long-awaited technology to prevent collisions. **B1.**

For disadvantaged, doors may close again

Fragile progress on racial wealth gap endangered by DEI backlash

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

The graduates of Resilient Coders have found life-changing jobs at tech companies across the country. One former retail employee went to work for Wayfair, which paid for him to get a master’s degree in computer science. An Uber driver who was barely scraping by became a coder at the same ride-sharing company — and now earns a six-figure salary.

But the program, which provides free software engineering training to people of color in Boston and Philadelphia, now finds itself in the crosshairs of a mounting anti-DEI fervor that equity advocates fear could threaten a wide range of efforts to level the playing field for people from diverse backgrounds — and undermine efforts to address the country’s widening racial wealth gap.

The Trump administration’s crackdown on diversity, equity, and inclusion has added fuel to a backlash that was already building following the 2023 Supreme Court decision to effectively end race-based affirmative action programs in college ad-

DEI, Page A7



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Joselyne Cordero, the first in her family to graduate from high school, has been helped by Digital Ready.